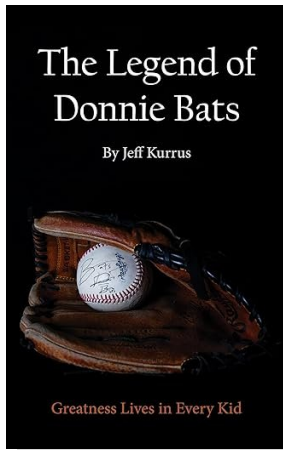


THE LEGEND OF DONNIE BATS

A standards-aligned chapter book for grades 3 to 5 · Educator Handout



Book overview

The Legend of Donnie Bats is a chapter book for reluctant readers in grades 3 to 5 (ages 7 to 12). Donnie can't hit, throw, or catch, but he loves the game anyway. The story follows him from the bench to the moment he discovers a hidden talent. Themes of effort without natural talent, the courage to keep trying, and the value of a hidden gift carry social and emotional learning alongside the literacy work.

Audience: grades 3 to 5 · **Reading level:** chapter book · **Author:** Jeff Kurrus, Nebraska

What's in the companion activity pack

Five discussion questions, a baseball-themed word search with a vocabulary matching activity, and the Be Like Donnie Challenge. Free for any classroom or library to copy and use.

Core ELA alignment (Common Core / Nebraska 2021 ELA, grades 3 to 5)

Discussion Questions 2 and 3 ask students to refer explicitly to a moment in the text and describe a character's traits and feelings (**RL.3.1, RL.3.3, RL.4.1, RL.4.3, RL.5.3**). **Question 4** asks students to choose between related words that describe states of mind (*brave, stubborn, determined*) and defend the choice, supporting **L.3.5.C** shades of meaning and **W.3.1 / W.4.1 / W.5.1** opinion writing with reasons. **Questions 1 and 5** ask for short opinion or narrative responses connecting the book to the student's own life (**L.3.5.B; W.3.3 / W.4.3 / W.5.3**). The **Be Like Donnie Challenge** produces a structured narrative recount with reflection and conclusion (**W.3.3.A, W.3.3.B, W.3.3.D**). The matching activity supports vocabulary acquisition through definition pairing (**L.3.4, L.3.6**). All discussion questions are designed for pair, group, or family conversation (**SL.3.1 / SL.4.1 / SL.5.1**).

English language learner support (WIDA ELD Standards Framework, 2020 Edition)

The activities engage all four **WIDA Key Language Uses**. **Narrate** (Questions 2 and 5; the Challenge), **Inform** (Question 1), **Explain** (Question 3), and **Argue** (Question 4). Every prompt offers both an interpretive and an expressive entry point. Students may draw, describe, or write, aligning with the **ELD-LA.3-5** Language Expectations and Proficiency Level Descriptors. The matching activity gives newcomer and developing learners a scaffolded entry point to domain-specific baseball vocabulary drawn directly from the book.

About the author

Jeff Kurrus is a Nebraska author and the editor of *Nebraskaland Magazine*. He is an award-winning photographer and the author of four children's books, including *Have You Seen Mary?*, a Nebraska Golden Sower Award nominee. He has visited K-8 classrooms across Nebraska for over ten years with a 45-minute author program.

Suggested classroom uses

Single-classroom unit. Pair the book with a five-day reading block. One discussion question per day, with the word search, vocabulary matching, and Be Like Donnie Challenge on day five.

Grade-level read. Distribute the book and pack to every grade 3 to 5 classroom. Schedule discussion across two weeks and close with student presentations of the Challenge.

Author visit anchor. Use the pack to prepare students for a Jeff Kurrus classroom visit. Students arrive with completed work in hand.

Send an email or visit the website to book a school visit, classroom program, or bulk order.